SQL FOR DATA ANALYSIS · LESSON 4 OF 15

DDL, DML & Constraints: CREATE, ALTER, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE

Create and change tables with DDL (CREATE, ALTER, DROP, TRUNCATE), add, change and remove rows with DML (INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE, MERGE), protect data quality with constraints (PRIMARY KEY, FOREIGN KEY, UNIQUE, NOT NULL, CHECK, DEFAULT, IDENTITY) and understand DELETE vs TRUNCATE vs DROP.

SQL classes 2–3 · SQL Server 2022, 2026 · Beginner · 120 min

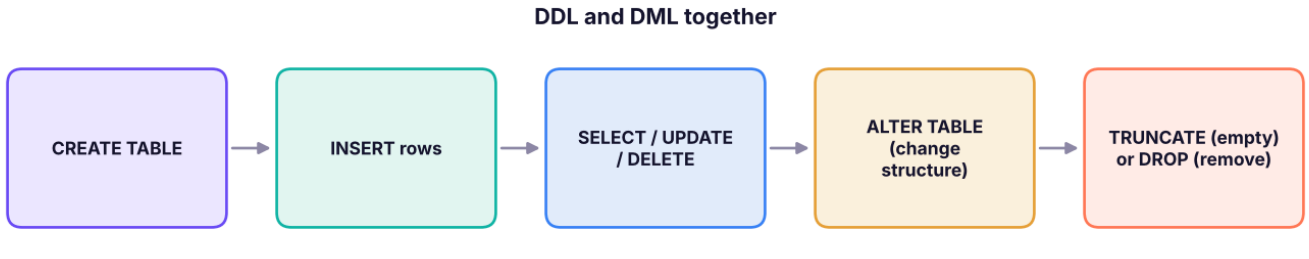
By the end of this lesson you can

- Create databases and tables with appropriate data types and constraints
- Modify table structure with ALTER TABLE (add, change, drop columns and constraints)
- Insert single and multiple rows, insert from a query, update and delete rows safely
- Explain every constraint type and read the error each one raises
- Compare DELETE, TRUNCATE and DROP, and use MERGE for upserts

Datasets used

`employees_small.csv`

The life cycle of a table



DDL creates and changes structure; DML fills and changes the rows inside it.

CREATE TABLE

SQL

```sql
CREATE TABLE departments (
    dept_id    INT          PRIMARY KEY,
    dept_name  VARCHAR(50)  NOT NULL UNIQUE,
    location   VARCHAR(50)  DEFAULT 'Bengaluru'
);

CREATE TABLE staff (
    emp_id     INT            PRIMARY KEY,
    full_name  VARCHAR(100)   NOT NULL,
    email      VARCHAR(100)   NOT NULL UNIQUE,
    dept_id    INT            NOT NULL REFERENCES departments(dept_id),
    salary     DECIMAL(10,2)  CHECK (salary > 0),
    join_date  DATE           DEFAULT CURRENT_DATE,
    is_active  BOOLEAN        DEFAULT TRUE
);
```

RESULT

```
Commands completed successfully.
Commands completed successfully.
```

In SQL Server you would usually write `IDENTITY(1,1)` for an auto-numbered key, `BIT` for the flag and `DEFAULT GETDATE()` for today. Here is the same `staff` table in full T-SQL style, with named constraints (names make error messages and later changes much easier):

SQL

```sql
CREATE TABLE dbo.staff (
    emp_id     INT IDENTITY(1,1)  NOT NULL,
    full_name  NVARCHAR(100)      NOT NULL,
    email      VARCHAR(100)       NOT NULL,
    dept_id    INT                NOT NULL,
    salary     DECIMAL(10,2)      NULL,
    join_date  DATE               NOT NULL CONSTRAINT df_staff_join  DEFAULT
(CAST(GETDATE() AS DATE)),
    is_active  BIT                NOT NULL CONSTRAINT df_staff_active DEFAULT (1),
    CONSTRAINT pk_staff         PRIMARY KEY (emp_id),
    CONSTRAINT uq_staff_email   UNIQUE (email),
    CONSTRAINT fk_staff_dept    FOREIGN KEY (dept_id) REFERENCES dbo.departments(dept_id),
    CONSTRAINT ck_staff_salary  CHECK (salary > 0)
);
```

Constraints at a glance

Constraint	Guarantees	Example
`PRIMARY KEY`	Unique and not NULL; identifies each row	`emp_id`
`FOREIGN KEY` / `REFERENCES`	Value must exist in the parent table	`dept_id` → `departments`
`UNIQUE`	No duplicate values (NULL allowed once in SQL Server)	`email`
`NOT NULL`	A value is required	`full_name`
`CHECK`	Value must satisfy a condition	`salary > 0`, `discount BETWEEN 0 AND 0.9`
`DEFAULT`	Value used when none is supplied	`is_active = 1`
`IDENTITY(seed, step)`	Auto-numbering (SQL Server)	`IDENTITY(1,1)`

INSERT: adding rows

SQL

```sql
INSERT INTO departments (dept_id, dept_name, location) VALUES
    (10, 'Finance', 'Mumbai'),
    (20, 'IT',      'Pune'),
    (30, 'HR',      DEFAULT),
    (40, 'Sales',   'Delhi');

INSERT INTO staff (emp_id, full_name, email, dept_id, salary, join_date) VALUES
    (1, 'Kavya Iyer',        'kavya@abc.in',    30,  97000, '2016-02-28'),
    (2, 'Imran Reddy',       'imran@abc.in',    10, 157000, '2019-12-14'),
    (3, 'Harpreet Kulkarni', 'harpreet@abc.in', 10, 131000, '2024-10-05'),
    (4, 'Rahul Iyer',        'rahul@abc.in',    20, 112000, '2017-02-06'),
    (5, 'Isha Mehta',        'isha@abc.in',     40,  57000, '2021-09-07');

SELECT * FROM departments;
```

RESULT

```
(4 rows affected)
(5 rows affected)
```

dept_id	dept_name	location
10	Finance	Mumbai
20	IT	Pune
30	HR	Bengaluru
40	Sales	Delhi

4 rows × 3 columns

SQL

```
SELECT emp_id, full_name, dept_id, salary, join_date, is_active FROM staff;
```

RESULT

emp_id	full_name	dept_id	salary	join_date	is_active
1	Kavya Iyer	30	97,000	2016-02-28	True
2	Imran Reddy	10	157,000	2019-12-14	True
3	Harpreet Kulkarni	10	131,000	2024-10-05	True
4	Rahul Iyer	20	112,000	2017-02-06	True
5	Isha Mehta	40	57,000	2021-09-07	True

5 rows × 6 columns

`DEFAULT` filled HR's location with Bengaluru and every employee's `is_active` with TRUE.

> **TIP** **Always list the columns**
>
> `INSERT INTO staff VALUES (…)` without a column list depends on the column order and breaks the day someone adds a column. Always write `INSERT INTO staff (col1, col2, …) VALUES (…)`.

INSERT … SELECT and SELECT … INTO

Copy rows from a query into a table:

SQL

```sql
-- Into an existing table
INSERT INTO staff_archive (emp_id, full_name, dept_id, salary)
SELECT emp_id, full_name, dept_id, salary
FROM staff
WHERE is_active = 0;

-- SQL Server: create a NEW table from a query (structure + data, no constraints)
SELECT emp_id, full_name, salary
INTO   staff_backup_2026
FROM   staff;
```

The portable equivalent of `SELECT … INTO` is `CREATE TABLE new_table AS SELECT …` (PostgreSQL, MySQL, Snowflake, DuckDB).

What constraints do when rules are broken

Constraints reject bad data **at the database**, whatever app or person sends it. These statements would all fail in SQL Server with the messages shown (abridged):

Statement	Broken rule	SQL Server message
`INSERT INTO departments VALUES (10,'Ops','Pune')`	PRIMARY KEY	Violation of PRIMARY KEY constraint 'pk_departments'. Cannot insert duplicate key … The duplicate key value is (10).
`INSERT INTO staff (…, email, …) VALUES (…, 'kavya@abc.in', …)`	UNIQUE	Violation of UNIQUE KEY constraint 'uq_staff_email'. Cannot insert duplicate key …
`INSERT INTO staff (…, dept_id, …) VALUES (…, 99, …)`	FOREIGN KEY	The INSERT statement conflicted with the FOREIGN KEY constraint "fk_staff_dept".
`INSERT INTO staff (emp_id, email, dept_id) VALUES (9,'x@abc.in',10)`	NOT NULL	Cannot insert the value NULL into column 'full_name' … column does not allow nulls. INSERT fails.
`UPDATE staff SET salary = -500 WHERE emp_id = 1`	CHECK	The UPDATE statement conflicted with the CHECK constraint "ck_staff_salary".
`DELETE FROM departments WHERE dept_id = 10`	FOREIGN KEY (children exist)	The DELETE statement conflicted with the REFERENCE constraint "fk_staff_dept".

Our practice engine raises the same kind of error. For example, trying to add an employee to a department that does not exist:

OUTPUT

```
Error: Constraint Error: Violates foreign key constraint because key "dept_id: 99"
does not exist in the referenced table
```

UPDATE: changing rows

SQL

```sql
-- Give everyone in Finance a 5% raise
UPDATE staff
SET    salary = salary * 1.05
WHERE  dept_id = 10;

-- Change two columns for one person
UPDATE staff
SET    dept_id = 20, salary = 60000
WHERE  emp_id = 5;

SELECT emp_id, full_name, dept_id, salary FROM staff ORDER BY emp_id;
```

RESULT

```
(2 rows affected)
(1 row affected)
```

emp_id	full_name	dept_id	salary
1	Kavya Iyer	30	97,000
2	Imran Reddy	10	164,850
3	Harpreet Kulkarni	10	137,550
4	Rahul Iyer	20	112,000
5	Isha Mehta	20	60,000

5 rows × 4 columns

WATCH OUT **UPDATE or DELETE without WHERE changes EVERY row**

`UPDATE staff SET salary = 0;` sets every salary to zero. Before any UPDATE or DELETE: 1. Write the `WHERE` first and run it as a `SELECT` to see exactly which rows will change. 2. Wrap the change in a transaction (`BEGIN TRAN` … then check, then `COMMIT` or `ROLLBACK`) (Lesson 14). 3. On production data, take a backup or work in a copy.

UPDATE with a join (SQL Server)

SQL

```sql
-- Mark staff in Mumbai departments as 'on-site'
UPDATE s
SET    s.work_mode = 'on-site'
FROM   staff AS s
JOIN   departments AS d ON d.dept_id = s.dept_id
WHERE  d.location = 'Mumbai';
```

DELETE: removing rows

SQL

```sql
DELETE FROM staff
WHERE emp_id = 5;

SELECT COUNT(*) AS staff_left FROM staff;
```

RESULT

(1 row affected)

staff_left
4

1 rows × 1 columns

ALTER TABLE: changing structure

SQL

```sql
ALTER TABLE staff ADD COLUMN phone VARCHAR(15);
ALTER TABLE staff ADD COLUMN work_mode VARCHAR(10) DEFAULT 'hybrid';
SELECT emp_id, full_name, phone, work_mode FROM staff;
```

RESULT

emp_id	full_name	phone	work_mode
1	Kavya Iyer	NULL	hybrid
2	Imran Reddy	NULL	hybrid
3	Harpreet Kulkarni	NULL	hybrid
4	Rahul Iyer	NULL	hybrid

4 rows × 4 columns

The SQL Server forms of the common changes:

```sql
ALTER TABLE staff ADD phone VARCHAR(15) NULL;                          -- add a column (no COLUMN keyword in T-SQL)
ALTER TABLE staff ALTER COLUMN full_name NVARCHAR(150) NOT NULL;       -- change type / nullability
ALTER TABLE staff DROP COLUMN phone;                                   -- remove a column
ALTER TABLE staff ADD CONSTRAINT ck_staff_mode CHECK (work_mode IN ('remote','hybrid','on-site'));
ALTER TABLE staff DROP CONSTRAINT ck_staff_mode;                       -- remove a constraint by name
EXEC sp_rename 'staff.full_name', 'employee_name', 'COLUMN';           -- rename a column
EXEC sp_rename 'staff', 'employees_master';                            -- rename a table
```

NOTE **Changing a column that has data**

Making a column smaller (`VARCHAR(100)` → `VARCHAR(10)`) fails if existing values do not fit; adding `NOT NULL` fails if NULLs exist. Clean the data first, or add a `DEFAULT`.

DELETE vs TRUNCATE vs DROP

This is one of the most common SQL interview questions.

	DELETE	TRUNCATE TABLE	DROP TABLE
Family	DML	DDL	DDL
Removes	Some or all **rows**	**All rows**	The **whole table**: rows, structure, indexes, constraints, permissions
WHERE allowed	Yes	No	No
Speed on large tables	Slower: logs each row	Very fast: deallocates pages	Fast
Logging	Every row logged	Minimal (page deallocations)	Minimal
Fires DELETE triggers	Yes	No	No
Resets IDENTITY	No	**Yes**, back to the seed	Table is gone
Works when referenced by a FK	Yes (if no child rows violate it)	**No**	**No** (drop the FK first)
Can be rolled back in a transaction	Yes	Yes in SQL Server (inside an explicit transaction)	Yes in SQL Server (inside an explicit transaction)

SQL

```sql
CREATE TABLE temp_log (id INT, msg VARCHAR(50));
INSERT INTO temp_log VALUES (1, 'start'), (2, 'load'), (3, 'end');
DELETE FROM temp_log WHERE id = 2;           -- removes one row
SELECT COUNT(*) AS after_delete FROM temp_log;
```

RESULT

```
Commands completed successfully.
(3 rows affected)
(1 row affected)
```

after_delete
2

1 rows × 1 columns

SQL

```sql
TRUNCATE TABLE temp_log;                    -- removes all rows, keeps the table
SELECT COUNT(*) AS after_truncate FROM temp_log;
```

RESULT

after_truncate
0

1 rows × 1 columns

SQL

```sql
DROP TABLE temp_log;                        -- removes the table itself
SELECT COUNT(*) AS tables_named_temp_log FROM information_schema.tables WHERE table_name =
'temp_log';
```

RESULT

tables_named_temp_log
0

1 rows × 1 columns

In SQL Server, `DROP TABLE IF EXISTS temp_log;` avoids an error when the table is already gone.

MERGE: insert or update in one statement (upsert)

Data pipelines often receive a file of changes: some rows are new, others update existing rows. `MERGE` handles both:

SQL

```sql
MERGE dbo.staff AS target
USING dbo.staff_updates AS src
      ON target.emp_id = src.emp_id
WHEN MATCHED THEN
     UPDATE SET target.salary = src.salary, target.dept_id = src.dept_id
WHEN NOT MATCHED BY TARGET THEN
     INSERT (emp_id, full_name, email, dept_id, salary)
     VALUES (src.emp_id, src.full_name, src.email, src.dept_id, src.salary)
WHEN NOT MATCHED BY SOURCE THEN
     UPDATE SET target.is_active = 0;          -- in staff but not in the file
```

Loading CSV files with SQL

```sql
CREATE TABLE dbo.employees_small (
    emp_id VARCHAR(10) PRIMARY KEY, name NVARCHAR(100), department VARCHAR(30),
    city VARCHAR(30), join_date DATE, salary DECIMAL(10,2), rating TINYINT
);

BULK INSERT dbo.employees_small
FROM 'C:\Data\employees_small.csv'
WITH (FORMAT = 'CSV', FIRSTROW = 2, FIELDTERMINATOR = ',', ROWTERMINATOR = '0x0a');
```

The SSMS **Import Flat File** wizard is easier for one-off loads; `BULK INSERT`, `bcp` or an ETL tool (SSIS, Azure Data Factory, Fabric pipelines) are used for repeatable loads.

DO IT WITH AI

Do it with AI

Ask: *"Write SQL Server CREATE TABLE statements with constraints for a hospital database: patients, doctors, appointments (a patient can see many doctors; a doctor sees many patients). Include primary keys, foreign keys, CHECK constraints for appointment status, and sensible data types."* Then review it: are the keys right, is money DECIMAL, are dates DATE/DATETIME2, are the constraints named?

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **DDL**: `CREATE`, `ALTER`, `DROP`, `TRUNCATE` change structure. **DML**: `INSERT`, `UPDATE`, `DELETE`, `MERGE` change rows.
- Constraints (PK, FK, UNIQUE, NOT NULL, CHECK, DEFAULT, IDENTITY) protect data quality at the source; name them.
- Always list columns in `INSERT`; always test the `WHERE` of an `UPDATE`/`DELETE` with a `SELECT` first, inside a transaction.
- `DELETE` removes chosen rows (logged, triggers fire); `TRUNCATE` empties the table fast and resets IDENTITY; `DROP` removes the table.
- `MERGE` performs upserts; `BULK INSERT` and the Import wizard load files.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. Which statement removes all rows but keeps the table structure and resets the IDENTITY counter?

A DELETE FROM t

B TRUNCATE TABLE t

C DROP TABLE t

D ALTER TABLE t

Answer: B. TRUNCATE empties the table quickly and resets IDENTITY to its seed.

2. You run `UPDATE staff SET salary = 50000;` by mistake. What happened?

A Only the first row changed

B Every row's salary is now 50,000

C Nothing, because there is no WHERE

D An error is raised

Answer: B. Without WHERE, UPDATE changes every row. Use transactions and test with SELECT first.

3. Which constraint stops a salary of −500?

A UNIQUE

B DEFAULT

C CHECK (salary > 0)

D FOREIGN KEY

Answer: C. CHECK validates values against a condition.

4. Inserting an employee with dept_id 99 fails with a FOREIGN KEY error. Why?

A dept_id must be unique

B No department with id 99 exists in the parent table

C dept_id cannot be a number

D The employee table is full

Answer: B. A foreign key value must exist in the referenced table.

5. Which is TRUE about DELETE?

A It can remove selected rows with WHERE and fires DELETE triggers

B It is DDL

C It resets IDENTITY

D It removes the table structure

Answer: A. DELETE is DML, works row by row with a WHERE, and fires triggers.

6. How do you add a column phone to `staff` in SQL Server?

A `ALTER TABLE staff ADD COLUMN phone VARCHAR(15)` only

B `ALTER TABLE staff ADD phone VARCHAR(15)`

C `UPDATE staff ADD phone`

D `INSERT COLUMN phone INTO staff`

Answer: B. T-SQL uses ADD without the COLUMN keyword (PostgreSQL/MySQL accept ADD COLUMN).

EXERCISE **Build and populate a small schema**

Create `projects(project_id PK, name UNIQUE NOT NULL, budget DECIMAL(12,2) CHECK budget ≥ 0, start_date DATE, status with CHECK IN ('planned','active','closed') DEFAULT 'planned')` and `assignments(project_id FK, emp_id FK, role, hours, PRIMARY KEY (project_id, emp_id))`. Insert 3 projects and 4 assignments, raise the budget of active projects by 10%, close one project, and delete assignments of closed projects.

Show solution (worked answer)

SQL

```
CREATE TABLE projects (
  project_id INT PRIMARY KEY, name VARCHAR(80) NOT NULL UNIQUE,
  budget DECIMAL(12,2) CHECK (budget ⩾ 0), start_date DATE,
  status VARCHAR(10) DEFAULT 'planned' CHECK (status IN
('planned','active','closed')));
CREATE TABLE assignments (
  project_id INT REFERENCES projects(project_id), emp_id INT REFERENCES staff(emp_id),
  role VARCHAR(30), hours INT CHECK (hours > 0), PRIMARY KEY (project_id, emp_id));
INSERT INTO projects (project_id, name, budget, start_date, status) VALUES
  (1,'CRM revamp',2500000,'2026-01-10','active'), (2,'Payroll audit',600000,'2026-03-
01','active'), (3,'Data lake',4000000,'2026-06-01','planned');
INSERT INTO assignments VALUES (1,1,'Analyst',120),(1,4,'Developer',300),
(2,2,'Lead',80),(3,3,'Architect',40);
UPDATE projects SET budget = budget * 1.10 WHERE status = 'active';
UPDATE projects SET status = 'closed' WHERE project_id = 2;
DELETE FROM assignments WHERE project_id IN (SELECT project_id FROM projects WHERE
status = 'closed');
```

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: DELETE vs TRUNCATE vs DROP? DELETE (DML) removes chosen rows with WHERE, logs each row, fires triggers and keeps IDENTITY. TRUNCATE (DDL) removes all rows quickly, minimal logging, resets IDENTITY, no WHERE, not allowed when referenced by a FK. DROP removes the whole table and its definition.

Q: What are constraints and why use them instead of app validation? Rules enforced by the database (PK, FK, UNIQUE, NOT NULL, CHECK, DEFAULT). They protect data no matter which app, script or person writes to the table.

Q: How do you safely run an UPDATE on production? Run the WHERE as a SELECT first, wrap in BEGIN TRAN, check @@ROWCOUNT and the result, then COMMIT or ROLLBACK; have a backup.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.